

SYDNEY MCLAUGHLIN-LEVRONE

(ATHLETICS)
ATHLETICS

Sydney McLaughlin-Levrone made switching disciplines look like a piece of cake. The 26-year-old American, having already established her dominance in the 400m hurdles with two Olympic golds, one World Championship title and the world record over the past five years, decided to run the 400m flat as her primary event this season. It was a huge risk since she had to compete against the Dominican Republic's Marileidy Paulino and Bahrain's Salwa Eid Naser, two of the fastest quartermilers in history.

The American, who had a personal best (PB) of 48.74s in the 400m before 2025, began the year clocking 50.32s in Jamaica in April. At the US trials for the World Championships, she brought it down to 48.90s. But no one could have imagined what she had in store for the biggest event of the year.

Despite rain pouring down on the track at the National Stadium in Tokyo, McLaughlin-Levrone clinched the world title by clocking 47.78s, breaking the 42-year-old championship record and narrowly missing out on Germany's Marita Koch's world record of 47.60s from 1985. For 40 years, no woman had gone sub-48 seconds over the 400m flat. Such was the American's impact that Paulino also clocked a new PB of 47.98s — the third-fastest time in history.

McLaughlin-Levrone, who was already great over the barriers, became the first athlete to win world titles in both the 400m flat and the 400m hurdles. She was named the Women's World Athlete of the Year by World Athletics.

Nihit Sachdeva

